



Lua

What is Lua?

Pronounced “loo-ah”, Lua is a new, free scripting language that’s gaining popularity with application and game developers alike.

Why is it so special?

Lua is a simple language to learn and write code in, but is still quick and efficient—a combination you rarely find with programming languages. It integrates well with C, C++ and Java, among others, so it’s very convenient for developers to use Lua to extend the features of their existing programs.

How does it work?

Much like Java, Lua code is interpreted when needed, rather than compiled like a C or C++ program. The code is translated into byte-code, which runs on Lua’s own virtual machine. It takes a load off programmers’ minds with automatic memory management, so they can focus on more important things like features. Lua code is also capable of modifying itself, making for some very flexible applications.

Who developed it?

Lua was developed at the Pontifical Catholic University of Rio de Janeiro in Brazil, and has been under the care of Tecgraf—the Computer Graphics Technology Group at the university.

When did it come on to the scene?

Lua was developed way back in 1993, and has been undergoing major improvements since.

Where can I see it in action?

An integral part of Adobe Photoshop Lightroom was written in Lua; game developers love it, too. *World of Warcraft*, for instance, uses Lua to allow users to customise the interface; a lot of the AI for *Company of Heroes* written in Lua.

to know about the most searched-for stuff on the Web, there’s the Google Zeitgeist, which gives you an account of the most searched-for terms in the weekly, monthly, and annual formats.

Now Google’s gone and done it again: come up with something we’d all appreciate. So here’s yet another search-based analysis tool for users—Google has combined Zeitgeist and Trends and named it “Hot Trends” to give you retrospective data about the search habits of Googlers.

Hot Trends will list the top 100 search trends rapidly rising, which gets refreshed based on the data of millions of search queries up to an hour before each update.

Amit Patel, a Hot Trends software engineer, said in a recent interview, “Google will help you find an explanation about what trends are interesting and why are they important enough to be listed.” Besides knowing the trends of an interesting term, one might want to try to find out the reasons behind the changes in its trends. For that, Hot Trends provides links to related sites, Google News stories, and blog searches for the trend you’re searching for. Hot Trends helps in knowing how a particular term or terms evolved over a period of time. By using Hot Trends, you can keep track of the 100 fastest-rising search trends and broader search patterns on the Web. Hot Trends is, as Google puts it, “a reflection of what people are searching for on Google today.” The all-new Hot Trends will leave out explicit language and terms, and will also have a focus on *change*—for example, even though “sex”

is still the most-searched for term, you won’t find a mention of it.

Interesting move, this—it is, as Google intended, better than the Zeitgeist, and more fun than Trends!

DOES IT HAPPEN HERE?

Sex Offenders On The Web

Social Networking is the cool thing amongst young people today, in America and elsewhere. But in the recent past, people have gotten duped, harassed, verbally assaulted, and even sexually abused by chatting through IMs in chatrooms and also via webcams. Individuals chat kinky with underage children.

Thanks to the social networking sites’ policy of not seeking any



Illustration Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

real-life identification while registering, it becomes difficult to trace the accused after a case of sexual abuse is filed. Today, sex offenders have taken to popular social networking sites like MySpace, Orkut, Xanga, Bebo, Facebook, and others. A recently-reported case was that of Judy Cajuste (14 years old) who met a 20-year-old male through MySpace, and who was later murdered.

MySpace has been facing a number of problems like identity theft, information revelation by kids below 14,

inappropriate material posting, and more. In the US, eight attorney generals of various states sent a letter to MySpace demanding the details of a “few thousand” registered sex offenders. MySpace recently agreed to release their database of sex offenders’ profiles.

In the virtual world called *Second Life*, there have been cases of child pornography: people have trading images. A user having child porn images will post a deal and sell them to anyone who seeks them.

Can such a situation be faced in India too? You’d think not, but it could well be. Be it cyber cafe, school, college, or home, young people are increasingly taking to social networking sites.

A case was reported about a Delhi girl wherein a spurned lover posted obscene messages on Orkut terming her a “Sex Teacher” along with her contact details. In Mumbai, a rejected lover in real life made a fake profile of the girl who spurned him, and posted messages on Orkut using pictures of the girl.

As more people are joining the online space, the potential of them being abused have increased. India-based networking sites like Yaari, Minglebox, Fropper, Rediff Connexions, and others have cropped up recently. Many have posted personal details in their public profiles on such sites. What the kids, teens, and even adults are doing is providing an open invitation to crank calls and obscene demands by offenders.

Spurned lovers find a place to vent at such sites, while predators look for sexual innuendos at such networking sites. Many have forgotten that their “scraps” are accessible by anyone. It’s not a pretty picture—and it’s not something we’d have foreseen even five years ago. ☒